Niyamgiri, Bhatta Parsaul, or in Mahuva, Gujarat, against a Nirma cement plant,' points out Ramesh.

Land acquisition in each of these instances had pitted tribals, Dalits and farmers versus big corporates. Rahul saw this as part of a greater Bharat versus India battle—he wanted to be seen on the side of the 'small guy'. He was labelled a 'jholawallah', more comfortable in the company of activists than corporate leaders.

Mamata Banerjee, too, had taken a similar anti-corporate stance in Bengal—her land agitations in Singur and Nandigram revived her political career. Mamata was a natural streetfighter. Rahul was, in the end, part of the ruling establishment. His agitational mode, therefore, lacked credibility and consistency. He almost seemed to flit in and out of a movement without actually taking a confrontational path that would reap political benefit. 'He felt a little trapped,' admits a senior Congressman. 'It wasn't easy to be seen as an activist and a powerful ruling party politician at the same time.'

Rahul's 'Bharat versus India' world view was perhaps shaped in his Cambridge years where he studied development economics as one of his 'core' papers. He also met and had dinner there with Nobel laureate Amartya Sen who was then Master at Trinity College. Sen later claimed that he was impressed with Rahul. 'He seemed deeply concerned about deprivation in India and wanting to make a change in that,' he told *Outlook* magazine in an interview. Interestingly, while looking back at his Cambridge years, Rahul told *Varsity* magazine, 'I'm a lot less left wing now than I was.' But in the Indian context, Rahul was firmly placed on the political left. While the Manmohan Singh government spoke of growth and market reforms, Rahul's language was one of rights and entitlements. It only created a certain fuzziness in policy approach at a time when the country needed clarity.

If Ramesh was seen as Rahul's economic fellow-traveller, then his early political guru was Digvijaya Singh. A former Madhya Pradesh chief minister, Singh had rather dramatically claimed after an electoral defeat in 2003 that he was taking 'sanyas' from political office for ten years. Submitting to political sanyas did not stop him, however, from becoming a